

Venezuelan Immigration and Integration to Trinidad and Tobago in Recent Years

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Abstract

When visualizing the map of the world, you would find Venezuela, a country popularized for its relevant economic, social, and political crisis. Taking a closer look to the northeast of this country, you can find a small island accompanied by a minuscule one compared to this nation; the Caribbean islands of Trinidad and Tobago. The distance between these two countries, from the nearest coasts to each other, is short: seven miles, or eleven kilometers. In their eyes, it is a resourceful and reliable option for civilians in desperation to flee to a safer environment. By risking their lives for lifelong opportunities, in the last six years, thousands of Venezuelans have suffered casualties, domestic violence, trafficking, discrimination and xenophobic treatments by the government of Trinidad and Tobago and some of its citizens. This paper informs about the issues they have undertaken and suffered upon their integration in the Caribbean islands in recent times as well as positives they have witnessed since 2019. It holds no intention to criticize or damage the reputation of the organizations or individuals within this paper, but to inform a crisis and to scale the significance of this integration occurring in a pair of islands no bigger than 5,131 square kilometers.

Humanitarian Crisis

Corruption, Inflation, Violence

The Venezuelan Crisis became the relevant issue known globally today as it intensified during mid-2014. As a petrostate, Venezuela's national government is highly dependent on income from fossil fuels with the economic and political powers embraced only by an elite minority, and thus corruption is widespread across the country. Over the years, Venezuela has become vulnerable to the Dutch's disease, a term applied to governments that only invest and maintain a specific sector; usually the oil and gas industries. With this lack of industrial infrastructure in other sectors like agriculture and manufacturing, unemployment skyrocketed and the dependence on the exportation of these resources became further unhealthier. As the government relies further on the income from the exportation of gas rather than the taxes from their society, they build harsher ties with the population.

As of recent years, according to the council of foreign relations, statistics indicated that oil exports had financed almost two-thirds of the Venezuelan government's budget. Their oil production had also dropped to their lowest level since 1945, with only 374,000 barrels of oil being produced per day, which is devastating for a country that heavily relies on oil exportation. Between 2014 to 2021, Venezuela's Gross Domestic Product shrank three quarters because of these poor productions and imports, as well as sanctions from the United States on their oil and gas sectors that have only worsened attempts on economic growth and prosperity. According to the Baker Institute, over the past few years, the investment on Venezuela's oil industries has worsened, as the quality and production facilities and factories worsened and thus Venezuela's main source of income was slowly collapsing since former Venezuelan President Hugo Chávez's presidency.

The United States of America has their reasons for sanctioning a country in a crisis because of the consecutive presidential terms executed by Nicolás Maduro. The PSUV socialist party (United Socialist Party of Venezuela), founded by Chávez, has gained control of key powers like the Supreme Court and most of the judiciary. Not long after Maduro's new position at the office, Venezuela went on a seven-year-recession where inflation skyrocketed and there was a massive shortage of basic goods. Not to mention, Anti-government protests by

communities in Venezuela would end up in mass arrests by the security forces that remained loyal to Maduro.

Shortly ago, the BBC and many other websites confirmed Maduro's given bounty of \$25 million USD for information leading to his arrest as the president was sworn for a third six-year term in office despite credible evidence for his loss. Along with the UK issuing sanctions on top Venezuelan officials, and Venezuela's continuation of undermining democracy, the rule of law, and human rights violations, according to the declaration of the Foreign, Commonwealth, and Development Offices. Ever since Hugo Chávez's placement in the office, Venezuela turned from a wealthy, democratic petrostate into a ruthless authoritarian dictatorship that has sought to rid all institutions asking for democracy and the rule of law.

This wasn't the only time the U.S has responded to a country led by corruption, as the BBC also has reported on that same recent article that the U.S charged Maduro and other senior officials with "narco-terrorism" in 2020. The use of drugs in the U.S was claimed to be transported by narcotraffickers in Venezuela with the help of Maduro and the country's senior officials. As expected, the president denied those accusations and only blamed the economic collapse on his country for the various sanctions that the U.S has imposed on them.

According to a report published by the U.S congress with details on each sanction imposed on Venezuela, there was evidence of sanctions on their oil sectors, the E.O. 13850 on 2019, freezing the assets of Venezuela's designation of Pétroleos (PdVSA) under management of the U.S Jurisdiction. Because of their maintained dependence on oil exports to fund operations and provision of basic goods and services, thus increasing the hyperinflation and poverty of the country's residents. More sectoral sanctions include the E.O. 13884 also in 2019, where Maduro's assets in the U.S were frozen and transactions with the government were prohibited. This further damaged Venezuela's options for financial growth via trading. The country's economy was plunged into despair with restrictions of dual-use technologies and transactions involving Venezuelan debt and sanctions against several high-ranking officials initiating and supporting corruption, autocracy, and the abuse of human rights. This worsened the internal government and led to a stronger instability in the country.

The Venezuelan government has been sanctioned with such consistency because of their continuous denial of rejecting the acknowledging of people's rights and a need for a solution to their crisis all because of Maduro's fear of losing his power. Because of his third term, it

continues to worsen from here. The hope of the Venezuelans only continues to decline as they realize that the sanctions, the corruption, and the inflation will slowly lead to more trying to fight against Maduro and end up persecuted as their voices are denied. What options do they have? All of those factors are pushing citizens of a decaying society to choose another place to go to for the opportunities they deserve as humans. Their ability to migrate to other countries is becoming more restricted and tougher each day that passes by and they await for Venezuela to change.

Trinidad and Tobago

This pressure is what leads Venezuelans to select countries that would grant them those opportunities of improved living conditions. They have to choose one. The official U.S Government Travel State Advisory issued on September 24, 2024 that Venezuela in itself is a Level 4 country in terms of travelling. This is a caution that recommends all people to not be in that country because of its several dangers. *“Do not travel to Venezuela due to the high risk of wrongful detentions, terrorism, kidnapping, the arbitrary enforcement of local laws, crime, civil unrest, poor health infrastructure.”*. Despite the report’s direction towards U.S citizens, all of these crimes and issues are what people suffer within the country. Those who object to Maduro's ideas in anti-Maduro demonstrations are reported to suffer with the following: *“the use of tear gas, pepper spray, and rubber bullets against participants, and which occasionally devolve into looting and vandalism.”* Security forces have also detained U.S citizens for up to five years, with the U.S government’s inability to act because of access to prisoners and their lack of notifications from Venezuela. Finally, Colombian terrorist groups operate in the border areas of the country, including borders to Colombia, Brazil, and Guyana, all of these being neighboring countries to Venezuela.

Even if they manage to survive all of these troubles, the option to go north towards central and north America is highly closed for them due to the extremely deadly route, the Darién Gap, which had 258 confirmed deaths between 2018 and 2023, while having 180 children abandoned on 2024 alone, the last one according to the president of Panama, José Raúl Molino. The International Federation of the Red Cross reported that this gap teems with surging river crossing, poisonous wild animals, and weather that can change unexpectedly. Human threats are also common in this migration route: robberies, smuggling, physical and sexual assault. This is evidently a path that hundreds of thousands of Venezuelans shouldn’t risk their lives for.

In north-eastern Venezuela, there are states like Sucre, Delta Amacuro, and Monagas where rural citizens of Venezuela are suffering from the effects of Maduro and the U.S sanctions. If they crossed across the country in any direction to migrate to one of the country's neighbors, they would be endangered from terrorism, murder, severe weather, shortages of food, water, medicine, and petrol. In other words, as a result of these life-taking risks, they are forced to flee from the country's crisis through the closest country possible.

A survey in July 2019 organized by the International Organization for Migration (IOM), known as their Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) had various recordings from 2,166 Venezuelan immigrants in Trinidad and Tobago following up the registrations of that year that allowed various Venezuelans to enter the country illegally and legally, mainly from the western part of the islands. In their responses, they found that 40.2% were born in Delta Amacuro, 11% born in Monagas and 10% in Sucre, all states extremely close to the Caribbean. Hence, based on these numbers and the humanitarian crisis at Venezuela, their most viable option to live better lives is to migrate to a Caribbean island that is drastically close in distance across sea: Trinidad and Tobago.

Dangers of Migration

Deadly Routes

"The first trip was horrible." stated Mariana, a Venezuelan housekeeper, *"We left from 5pm and reached 9pm by boat, with 18 people, 3 were under age. I got here illegally."* Mariana had lived in Monagas's Capital, which is at the northeast of the country and is one of the three Venezuelan states closest to Trinidad. She arrived from Güiria, the capital city of the Valdez Municipality in the state of Sucre in northeastern Venezuela, and reached Chaguaramas, the northwestern peninsula of Trinidad. Güiria is a port where several Venezuelans take to reach the northern ports in Trinidad. However, various issues and struggles have been evident across the several routes that Venezuelans have taken in hope of better opportunities for themselves and their families.

"While sneaking into T&T may be easy, the UN High Commissioner for Refugees' office stated on Thursday that Venezuelans risk land mines and armed groups en route to Colombia."

(*Trinidad & Tobago Guardian*) The viability of Trinidad is highly considered, especially by the Venezuelans struck further by the crisis due to poverty and a lack of human resources. This grand majority of Venezuelans decide to flee through boats via the eastern coasts of the country because of its affordability, and despite the dangers, it has become an essential destination for Venezuelans attempting to escape their humanitarian crisis.

As attested by the Assessment Capacities Project Organization (ACAPS), nearly 45,000 Venezuelan immigrants, refugees, and asylum seekers lived in Trinidad and Tobago as of November 2023. This, also outlined by ACAPS, was the highest per capita population of Venezuelans in the Caribbean (as of 2024). In terms of refugees, this source also reported that 85% registered with UNHCR in Trinidad are of Venezuelan origin. This number and percentage of individuals mostly took this option of immigrating to the islands, and several didn't stay alive during the trip. Not to mention, in the IOM's survey towards Venezuelans, 12% took an aerial method of transportation to reach their destination, while the massive 88% preferred going through the rigorous sea. There was also a graph that followed a trend where younger refugees had a higher percentage of travelling through sea than air compared to senior citizens. 96% of those younger than 20 had taken the sea routes, while only 81% of adults older than 60 took this method as well (*International Organization for Migration*). Their more recent DTM published in late 2023, interviewing over 1,300 Venezuelans, shows a difference of 7% taking an aerial method of transportation while the rest took on the seas.

Despite the dangers of the sea, some who had legal documentation instead preferred to travel by ferry, which was the case for some Venezuelans that had family members with Trinidadian nationalities. In several interviews, immigrants who lived further by the center or west of Venezuela were more likely to take a safer, and further viable method of transportation to reach their destination, while those living further in the east were more likely to take more dangerous alternatives.

The two largest routes taken by Venezuelans via boats are across *Bocas del Dragón* (Dragon's Mouths) by the Northeast coast, and *Boca de la Serpiente* (Snake's Mouth) near the Southeast coast. The main reason for the popularity of these routes is the geographical shape of the mainlands. The two routes are distances that are very short compared to other potential routes and thus less likely to suffer from further dangers of the sea. *Bocas del Dragón* has been

considered to be an incredibly dangerous route due to human smuggling, narco-trafficking, shipwrecks, and piracy.

Early on February 20, 2025, very recently from the publishing of this report, a boat carrying 25 Venezuelans to Trinidad and Tobago capsized as the boat's engines turned off in the middle of the sea. *"My sister was rescued and is being treated by doctors. Her 11-month-old baby was next to her, lifeless. My oldest niece is still missing."* (*The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*) This was stated by Yusleivi Ramirez, who travelled in the boat with two of his sister's daughters: one 11-month-old who had passed away due to this incident. Regardless of how many people are missing, the Trinidad and Tobago Newsday attested that the TT Coast Guard and Ministry of National Security are addressing a search although not assisting directly. These routes have caused a loss of life for people of all ages, and they are helpless considering they are fleeing from their home country to reach a country that will likely deport them for illegal immigration.

Multiple cases of shipwreck and death have been evident occurring within this migration route. According to The New Humanitarian, in 2019, three boats were reported to be missing, which was equivalent to the loss of 80 people on board. In early 2021, there was another case of shipwreck through this route in which out of 24 Venezuelans, 17 were dead or presumed dead. What's worse is that 80% of respondents on the IOM's 2019 DTM survey reported having spent between \$100-500 USD for their travels, which took transportation across the sea, only to have paid for some of them to lose their lives.

Major difficulties were prevalent during the trip to arrive at a new home. The 2023 DTM had respondents of their survey report what their primary issues were during said voyage. While the majority, 38%, did not report any difficulties, 18% saw a lack of food and water, 10% lacked sleep, 9% were in need of economic resources, 7% were insecure or robbed about their smugglers, and 6% suffered from lack of information.

These risks of life in order to escape the humanitarian crisis is undeterred when one considers the mass deportations organized by the Trinidadian Ministry of Security. According to the Human Rights Watch, days after 160 refugees were deported back to Venezuela for illegally migrating to the islands in an attempt to reunite with their families for Christmas of 2020. They traveled back to Trinidad only for 36 Venezuelans, several children included, to drown between the coast of Güiria and the island of Trinidad.

Another case occurred on February 5th of 2022, where 35 out of 39 Venezuelans on a vessel were deported despite the fact that out of the 39, an infant one-year old Ya Elvis Santoyo had died from bullet wounds from a Coast Guard on the TTS Scarborough ship guarding the borders. His mother, shot as well, was gravely injured and sent to recover shortly at the Sangre Grande hospital. However, the Coast Guard claims his reasons for shooting the vessel was due to the “aggressive maneuvers” of the pirogue with the migrants. He claimed they were ramming on the TTS Scarborough. He continued by stating that they attempted to shoot at the engine of their ship as self-defense, which led to the accidents. Even if the actions of the migrant pirogue were unjustified, it is an absolute violation to open fire at innocent migrants attempting to flee their country for better lives. A vessel as small as a pirogue is no danger to a battleship, and it was continued to be regarded as an act of self-defense to shoot at the engine nearby the Venezuelan migrants. Fortunately, this incident had led Trinidadian forces at their borders to balance their security with humanitarian considerations and improve their protocols in the interception of migrant vessels. The law should never be forced to commit homicide on refugees in search of a place that can allow them to live properly.

Violations through Deportations

Beatriz Borges, the director of the Venezuelan civil society *Cepaz*, stated that the Venezuelan migrants attempting to immigrate to Trinidad were drawn by the tourism industry for work opportunities, and how most of them haven’t received health support, proper nutrition, or proper resource consumption for years and were thus in horrible conditions to be surviving trips like those. Based on a UN report, a third of the whole Venezuelan population was recently in need of food assistance. Malnourished migrants attempting to migrate taking very dangerous methods and routes of transportation signals the suffering of the Venezuelan people only to be deported back to Venezuela with their children left alone; in danger.

In Trinidad and Tobago, there are deportations of Venezuelans on a daily basis, although there are moments where in a short period of time, mass amounts of people are deported at the same time, and there have been several instances where this has occurred across recent years. These deportations, considering the deaths of hundreds of Venezuelan refugees under unhealthy conditions, and while under the law, disregard the sincere amount of trouble Venezuelans go through to reach Trinidad and Tobago and do not respect the human rights refugees deserve.

Infobae implies that protests have already occurred in Güiria, Venezuela, concerning the deaths of refugees in Trinidad and their bodies not being returned to their families, which only led Gustavo Tarre Briceño, a representative of Venezuela in the Organization of the American States (OAS), to remark on a meeting with an inter american commission of human rights about the treatment of Venezuelan migrants in Trinidad and Tobago.

The situation with Venezuelan arrivals increases numbers that create a strain on their necessary resources due to the lack of international detention centers in the islands. Several news outlets confirm that on November 23rd, 2020, thirteen adults and sixteen children from Venezuela were forcefully deported to their country six days after arriving without regard to the harsh weather conditions at sea at that moment. Published by the New Atlanticist, an article stated that those same deportees were detained and supposed to have a court hearing regarding their stay in Trinidad. Nevertheless, they were deported regardless as they were falsely informed by Trinidad's courts. With human rights organizations such as Amnesty International reporting dozens of Venezuelan deportations for Trinidad and Tobago, they argued that the islands violated the obligations they had under international law.

TTT Live Online reported that Venezuelans, in mid-2019, were requesting registration for Amnesty via their illegal migration to Trinidad. They were given two weeks to do this by the Former Prime Minister of Trinidad and Tobago, Keith Rowley. 16,500 Venezuelans were thus able to register for amnesty this same year. *"This has been renovated year through year,"* says Amanda Solano, a protection officer in the Trinidad and Tobago UNHCR, *"This Registration Framework is a very good practice. It's a very positive act by the state to establish protection for the Venezuelan people."* While successful, amnesty was not provided for those who came after the period of registration or even those who arrived at that time but weren't allowed for unknown reasons.

The Prime Minister had exclaimed something of regard as part of his speech: *"The policy of Trinidad and Tobago remains; if you did not register during that period of registration, I have instructed the minister of national security to deport every single one of them."* (Keith Rowley, TTT Live Online) While illegally migrating is against the law according to his words, people are forced to migrate to the nearest country at any time regardless of that host country's economic status or migration policies based on the economical crisis, abuse of political power, crime, persecution, and major losses of employment going on in Venezuela.

According to Solano, having amnesty as a refugee gave Venezuelans the right to work and to access emergency health care. This was minimal, as they still had no right for education, to hold bank accounts, or higher levels in healthcare treatments. These, while very little, were necessities that could sustain the lives of these refugees better than remaining in a country with severe financial strains. Either you had this small accessibility to resources, or you were deported back to the country that risked your own life or your family's.

Considering the country's pandemic situation in 2020, deportations were only much stronger violations of international law caused by Trinidad and Tobago. Louise Tillotson, a researcher in Amnesty International working on the Caribbean, reported that 165 Venezuelans, in recent weeks, were forced to return to their homeland despite the COVID-19 crisis. It was also reported by the media that Venezuelans were arrested and quarantined in July of that year. All of this puts the island's treatment of their migrants and their rights in doubt. Tillotson had some words towards this. *"To deport Venezuelan refugees back to the human rights and humanitarian emergency that they were fleeing, in the middle of a pandemic, is an outrageous violation of the obligations that Trinidad and Tobago has committed to under international law. No one should be forced back to a place where they are at risk of serious human rights violations."* (Louise Tillotson, Amnesty International) While the pandemic has already reached its conclusion, it is evidence that despite both the global and Venezuelan crisis, which were seriously damaging the lives of thousands of migrants, they were denied their requests of amnesty and asylum regardless of the harm to human life.

BBC News also reported that despite their allowance to work, Venezuelans only had a work allowance of about a year. Furthermore, the inter-american commission on human rights has stated that the government of Trinidad has the responsibility to satisfy the migrants in their country and ensure their safety in best interest. CNC3, one of the official television channels on Trinidad and Tobago, reported that in 2022, Venezuelans claimed the continuation of their deportation despite their signed and confirmed amnesties. One of them who lived in Trinidad for three years was deported back despite the time he spent in the islands. Jorge Henríquez, an immigration lawyer who directs the refugee freedom project in Trinidad concluded that deporting the Venezuelans was a simpler task for the government rather than taking the process of granting them asylum.

“From my understanding, many of them are holders of identification cards issued by the UNHCR. And this provides international protection for that individual not to be forced to return to their country.” (Criston J Williams, Trinidad & Tobago Guardian) Mass arrests were of relevance because of this idea that all undocumented migrants, even those with identification provided by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) were placed under arrest. On July 11th, 2023, nearly 191 Venezuelan migrants, 96 male and 95 female between the ages of 17 to 46 were all sent to the Heliport at Chaguaramas to await deportation. These accusations were only supported by a local activist for the Venezuelan refugees, Miss Yesenia Gonzales. *“She said the State had more serious issues to address than undocumented people enjoying a night out.”* The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian reported, *“Gonzales claimed some of the detainees had been granted amnesty, but had not been in possession of their “cards” when held yesterday.”* She showed sorrow over the failure of the authorities to focus on real crime rather than the arrest of these individuals only searching for opportunities that suit them better.

On November 26th, 2024, Yvonne Webb’s published piece of news on the Trinidad and Tobago Newsday had some words of former Prime Minister and leader of the opposition party of Trinidad and Tobago, Kamla Persad-Biessar, who had a response for an abduction and murder of a penal pensioner called Winston Thomas five days earlier with claims that the orchestration of the crime was by a Venezuelan. *“Today I make it clear. If the Venezuelan migrant community do not get their act in order and desist from engaging in criminal conduct, begin assisting the police service in identifying Venezuelan criminals and integrate peacefully into our society, my incoming government will take aggressive action against ALL illegal Venezuelan migrants and deport every one of them to their homeland by any means necessary.” (Kamla Persad-Biessar, The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday)* This is coming from another rise in homicide rates in Trinidad, as in May 2023 she was in a more positive position towards the Venezuelans, calling on the government to improve the quality of life of Venezuelan migrants in terms of education, health care, and overall stay at Trinidad and Tobago.

When asked what the Venezuelans and refugees were in need of the most, Amanda Solano of the UNHCR responded that the access to a legal framework, which isn’t available to the refugees, should be implemented in order for people to request for protection as refugees against the authorities of Trinidad and Tobago. Having a law or legislation like this one would initiate said protection, which would also allow the request for asylum, to be able to document,

to know what rights they have access to. *“If there was something I would choose, it would be legislation for asylum.”* she concludes. The constant deportation of the migrants would need them to have a privilege like this one in order to assure their safety and for them to be able to earn the rights they ultimately deserve for risking their lives for the establishment of stability for themselves and their families, not to be sent back after that effort. The UNHCR has been responsible for facilitating the registration process for refugees and continues to do so in hopes for a more safe integration of the refugees in dire need.

On their recent years of arrival to Trinidad and Tobago through a treacherous and deadly journey that has led to the death of hundreds, it has reflected the true fear and danger evoked from the humanitarian crisis in Venezuela. They arrive malnourished because of that same crisis, and after all those pains have to go through xenophobia, discrimination, and worse of all, deportation. According to the more recent DTM published by the International Organization for Migration, 71% of Venezuelans remain unaware when they will proceed to leave the islands. They are vulnerable individuals who will continue to arrive and must be granted basic human rights rather than being detained and deported as refugees fleeing from a decaying country.

Xenophobia and Trafficking

Human & Sex Trafficking

Yosqueili, a 16 year old from Güiria, Venezuela, was given \$2000 to migrate to Trinidad along with her cousin in order for them to earn jobs so that they can collect money and contribute to their families' desperate financial situation. On a night, the date being April 23rd, 2019, due to the dangers of Bocas del Dragón, only 9 out of the 37 people survived a shipwreck, as she realized the real reason why she was given such an offer: To be sold off as a prostitute in Trinidad and Tobago. Even when escaping alive, Yosqueili accused the human trafficking ring that captured her, and when both a global quarantine and fear of what could happen to them came, it was too late as a group of people invaded their humble home with weapons. She was forced to go with them as they threatened to further hurt her mother. In this way, Yosqueili was sold off for \$300 as a prostitute in Trinidad and Tobago simply because she hoped and took action when seeking better opportunities in her life. (*Caracas Chronicles*)

Amnesty International confirms the issue involving women from Venezuela at a high risk of being trafficked into the sex sector of Trinidad, in order for traffickers to benefit from human rights abuses. Trinidadians travel to towns with ports in Venezuela coasts, like Güiria, in search of victims to exploit and make money with. This is confirmed by a 25 year old who works in falsifying passports to allow those in Güiria to flee to Trinidad illegally. They worked daily and continued to send more girls across the sea. The man also claimed that selling off a woman to prostitution can go above \$300 per woman, becoming a very lucrative business of exploitation of teenage and younger women. They are forced to take themselves nude pictures of themselves in order for the buyer to approve them only for them to be sent on ships to Trinidad without knowing the business they were going to be plunged into. *“Trinidadian fishermen are a major trafficking medium between Venezuela and the 132 points of entry on Trinidad’s southern coast.” (Trinidad and Tobago’s Newsday)* The Venezuelans' aspiration to earn better lives is what gives them the impulse of trusting these fishermen to send them to the country, only for them to be exploited by traffickers.

This whole process undertakes three steps: Recruitment, Transportation, Exploitation. There exist various routes traffickers take to recruit Venezuelan women into their lucrative business. Both the Venezuelan cities of Tucupita (in the Delta Amacuro state), and Carúpano (in the Sucre state), are mass transit/recruitment centers, according to the InSight criminology organization. But many have stayed in the nation, increasingly vulnerable to being recruited, or even kidnapped, by human traffickers. *“Research from the Venezuelan Violence Observatory (Observatorio Venezolano de Violencia — OVV) has suggested populations in border states face greater risks of being trafficked.” (InSight Crime)* Other locations within border states of Venezuela that take routes of trafficking include Güiria, Irapa and Maturín.

Once arriving at Trinidad, victims are forced into prostitution, and are exploited in bars, private beaches, and other locations including a high demand in the Chaguanas Borough. Both physical and psychological issues derive from activities against these migrants who arrived with the sole purpose of preventing issues like those from happening to them. The owners of brothels where the women are sent to do these forced services pay bribes to authorities in order to continue the operations for them to make further profit out of these violations of human rights.

Andreina Briceño Ventura-Brown from the La Casita Hispanic Cultural Centre informed in an interview that the women who are forced into these kinds of lucrative and inhumane

businesses can range from ages that can go as low as 11 years of age, speaking of which was an actual case for a minor who was involved in sex trafficking with the hope that it would help her family from the humanitarian crisis in Venezuela. Multiple cases have also existed with girls of 13, 14, and 15 years of age. There is no consideration with the ages of the victims for this crime, and criminals are fully determined to exploit whoever can generate easy money for them regardless of their innocence.

Venezuelan women in Trinidad and Tobago are often turned into sex work as well once they run out of options for financial stability and/or to send money to their families. The New Humanitarian brought Sara Gómez, an undocumented migrant, to give some words about her experiences in Trinidad and Tobago. *“I used to be a teacher in Venezuela. I don’t like my job here, and it pays worse than minimum wage. But at least they don’t beat me.”* Gómez also reported being physically assaulted and robbed by her former employer at her job as a janitor for a fast food restaurant. *“Opportunities here for migrants, especially women, are very limited,”* Gómez concerns over deportation, as if she were to report the robbery as an offense to the police, as they will deport her from her lack of documentation and their corruption against Venezuelans. Julio Henríquez of the Freedom Refugee Project had stated the increasing crisis of sexual trafficking in Trinidad. Cases where women are afraid to go to the police and even a fraction of them had to resort to such a business to pay off the debt smugglers placed into them for hoping to move to the islands.

A 2020 human trafficking report published by the United Nations office on Drugs and crime informed that between the years 2017 and 2018, out of 16 cases of trafficking, 13 were Venezuelan women in Trinidad and Tobago. Henríquez argues that the government does not release further information involving the data involving the amount of trafficking on Trinidad. *“They have created a system that incentivises ignoring these issues. The very same governmental bodies that are supposed to protect them have failed.”* is what he stated. According to the U.S Department of State’s 2023 Trafficking in Persons Report, *“The Government of Trinidad and Tobago does not meet the minimum standards for the elimination of trafficking but is making significant efforts to do so”*. The source also claims that the government of the islands has implemented new SOPs for victim referral and care while also opening shelters for them. It also reported that under the 2011 Persons Act on trafficking, courts have never convicted a trafficker since then. The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian also reported that in 2020, the government did not

take action despite allegations that senior government officials were involved in the human trafficking stage. The Department of State also informed that Trinidad has remained on a Tier 2 Watch List on Protecting Victims from Trafficking rather than a downgraded Tier 3 for its third consecutive year. The reason why it's not fully tier 2 but a Watch List has been because of the rise of cases of trafficking while the country's governments don't regard it as much despite their significant efforts. When in the Tier 2 watch list, one is at the verge of Tier 3, hinting that this could occur if the authorities continued disregarding this crisis involving the Venezuelans. The government's need to increase efforts in prosecuting traffickers, including officers of law enforcement, and place punishments for their crimes, as it came from the same source.

The US State Department gives these rankings based on the governments' engagement with the Violence Protecting Act of 2000 (TVPA), in which the Government of Trinidad and Tobago has not fully complied with the minimum standards that are listed on the TVPA, although continues applying said significant efforts in order to not fall into a ranking that labels them as a government that are making no effort to cease of the crime that is trafficking.

Effectively, women were sold into sex slavery. Networks of this business included law enforcement officials, international criminal organizations, and corrupt rogue officials. The Trinidad Guardian published a news article about a 2019 CARICOM research organized by Dr. C. Justine Pierre along with Nayrobis Rodriguez that had them investigate traffickers, smugglers, officers and anti-human trafficking organizations from about 32 countries. A Venezuelan trafficker had revealed his connections with the police service in Trinidad and Tobago (TTPS), and another trafficker reported his collaboration with another officer who paid for women to be brought to the islands for the sex market. This trafficker had his phone number, although when approaching that same officer, he questioned the validity of the accusations against him. The arrest of a former criminal who led an organized crime gang involved in the trafficking, 'El Monky', was found in possession of a phone number with a police officer. It suggests that the success of human-right violation crimes like sex trafficking has derived from the willingness of authorities to gain profit from the engagement of this crime.

An analysis involving sex trafficking in the Caribbean estimated that between 2013 and 2019, the Trinidad and Tobago Police reported 484 cases of human trafficking. Counter Trafficking Unit sources also reported to the Trinidad Guardian in 2022 that the majority of the trafficking activities were occurring in the center of the main island, with the most Venezuelans

and migrants arriving through the Piarco International Airport or at the southwestern peninsula of Trinidad. Data of those cases was collected since 2013, in which 99% of all victims were foreign, Venezuelans being by far the most affected. The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday also informed that of the 63 charged between 2013 and 2024, most of them were nationals from Trinidad and Tobago. The same source reported that the Government has reported 38 trafficking and 36 sex-trafficking victims. However, Non-Governmental Organizations estimate these numbers going up to 500, during a two-year period.

Thus, numbers could only be higher. A 2021 report published by the NGO Connectas finds that 21 thousand Venezuelan women and young girls, most being between the ages of 18-25. The report by the NGO also concludes that out of the 60,000 Venezuelans in Trinidad at the time, there could be so many that they comprised 10% of the whole Trinidadian population. However, only 9 thousand of these migrants had legal status and entry to the country. *“Figures from the Trinidadian Financial Intelligence Unit showed that in the four years to 2020, human trafficking added \$2.2 million USD to the country's economy, according to the Connectas report.”* (Jusoor Post) In this way, this form of exploitation and violation of human rights is in fact, somewhat beneficial, to the economy of Trinidad.

Much more recently, in October 2024, two intelligence-led operations involving the sex issue trafficking occurred in Trinidad. The first was on the 8th of that month, in which 11 Venezuelan women were allegedly, as Trinidad & Tobago's Newsday reports it, held as victims of human trafficking. This operation took place in Ragoonanan Road, Cunupia, where three suspects, one female and two male were held and were in custody of the police for further investigations.

In the second, there was a 'human trafficking' raid, as a piece of news from Trinidad Express labels it, where 12 Venezuelan women between the ages of 18 and 32 were rescued and sent to the St Joseph Police Station. They were held at a house in Fletcher Street, Mt. Lambert. Only one out of the 12 women had legal entry to Trinidad and Tobago, while the remaining had entered the borders of the country illegally.

While recent efforts have been made by the government of the islands towards stopping the relevant sex trafficking against the Venezuelan refugees, it remains as a case that isn't fully addressed as these are innocent individuals fleeing from a crisis who are exploited in order to help criminals make wealth while playing with the lives of human beings. Venezuelan refugees

integrate to Trinidad and Tobago with the desperate purpose of finding a safer location to live only to be plunged into crimes that have cost their bodies.

Xenophobic Accusations & Violence

Andreina Briceño Ventura-Brown from La Casita Hispanic Cultural Centre and an activist for Gender-based violence in Trinidad and Tobago implied that if there was a time where Xenophobia had never been the same for Venezuelans in Trinidad and Tobago, it was since the registration of Venezuelans in 2019. In times prior to this year, the Venezuelans were seen as a smaller community that was essential to the islands because of the cultural and international diversity that it expressed as well as their ability to speak the Spanish language. In 2020, a year later, she was shot on her left shoulder during a home invasion in Arima by three bandits, one armed. She was shocked for four months due to the injury, and had thoughts of leaving the country, although had one reason for not leaving. This was to continue supporting her community center - La Casita, which she opened in 2017 to give support services to refugees and migrants, as well as victims of Gender-based violence. The building reopened in 2020 after difficulties concerning rent and the COVID-19 Pandemic. (*Trinidad & Tobago Guardian*)

“In July 2020, Trinidad and Tobago’s security minister called Venezuelans ‘boat people’ who ‘represented a serious health issue’, and gave the number of a hotline for residents to report those without documentation.” (The New Humanitarian) Speaking of the COVID-19 pandemic, this world-wide disease had struck the world in the early year 2020, and has already been concluded since May 2023 according to the World Health Organization. Nevertheless, the pandemic in Trinidad and Tobago was negatively and drastically impactful for its Venezuelan community that had massively arrived a year prior to the pandemic. The migration of Venezuelans to the Caribbean islands had generated speculations that the spreading of COVID-19 was promoted by their arrival. Both the New Humanitarian and Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights report on “Push Backs” mention that ministers, officials, and politicians of high level in the nation insult these Venezuelans and give them labels, which is what drives the society within the islands into having xenophobia and turning against those who seek refuge for their survival and to provide for their families.

“The government wants to blame their failings on outsiders, and the COVID crisis has made this worse.” (The New Humanitarian) These words come from Manuel Romero, a

Venezuelan refugee granted asylum from death threats to him and his family in Venezuela by intelligence services and a liaison for the Living Water company. Both the mass Venezuelan registering of 2019 and the COVID-19 of 2020 were coincidences that correlated with each other. *“Xenophobia wasn't common among the people here when I arrived in 2018, Trinidadian people are very kind and welcoming. But I have seen the rhetoric from public officials grow darker ever since.”* (The New Humanitarian). Evidence from Venezuelans define the significant shift in perspective of Trinidadian society once a wide-spread disease arrived as soon as refugees massively migrated. They are blamed for the spread of COVID-19 and thus the government prevents the access of more Venezuelans who are only coming to seek opportunities that suit their situation. All societies were struck by this disease and it was inevitable that Trinidad would be hit as well, blaming it entirely on a community fleeing from a situation that has cost them their own lives was rushed and indecisive.

“While government data is limited, unemployment and underemployment are visible and acute problems. These conditions make it easy to criminalise certain groups of migrants, such as those who arrive by boat from Venezuela.” (University of West Indies) Venezuelans are blamed for several of Trinidad’s issues that were started by COVID-19. This includes rising unemployment, a decrease in wages, and even divorce where Venezuelan women would face stigmatization, as they were accused of starting relationships with the locals. These allegations against the refugee and migrant community is what separated them further from the migrants and built a weaker relationship between the two.

“There is too much xenophobia.” Mariana stated. *“They dropped the F-bomb at us, ‘F*cking Spanish’, slurs like those.”* Trinidadians have used offensive language against the Venezuelans, showing their great opposition and hatred towards those who arrived back in 2019 for the two week amnesty period that allowed Venezuelans to legally live and work for about a year. *“‘Prostitutes’, ‘Go back home’ and ‘just now you all will eat grass’ were among the remarks some commuters travelling along the SS Erin Road near the Achievors Banquet Hall in Duncan Village shouted to the Venezuelan migrants.”* (Trinidad & Tobago Guardian) The Guardian’s report towards this issue heavily describes the harsh environment the Venezuelans were placed in. The slurs against the Venezuelans sincerely elicit an overwhelming sense of hatred against communities that are only there to save their lives or to only see the opportunities of returning money back home to provide for their hungry, impoverished families.

These kinds of experiences aren't very nice when attempting to access the country as a Venezuelan. Alejandra reported her experiences in her process of migration to Trinidad about bad treatments towards her. *"Another experience that I remember well was my first time immigrating to Trinidad,"* she initiated. *"And since my father was from Trinidad, I needed to seek the information to prove my nationality, and the lady that attended me told me to leave and I sought for a translator, she treated me badly, which made me sad."* Despite her connections, she was still treated like that once she lacked ability in the English language. A Trinidadian could've been there to help out with translations, although the xenophobia caused this treatment and did not acknowledge possibilities of translators coming to assist the migrants with the language barrier.

Ernesto, as the University of West Indies (UWI) named him, fled Venezuela with his brother and his brother's family to settle in a neighborhood at Trinidad, only for locals nearby to express their direct hostility against the refugees. They ordered him to "go back" during daily activities, he had this sense of danger from threats coming from the locals and gave him this sense of fear when he should feel safe after fleeing the devastating crisis in his homeland. Ernesto suffers from a lack of resources to mitigate any risks of deportation or detention, which are state policies. Especially in times of pandemic, where social safety networks were disrupted and Venezuelans couldn't gain much access from it, spreading the idea that refugees have no right for any social support.

Rising Xenophobia in recent years has led to mass deportations in Trinidad and Tobago. The OHCHR report on "Push Backs" that primarily focuses on Venezuelans in the islands has a detailed account on a refugee, Neymar José Heredia, who arrived during the period of registration in 2019 with the purpose of financially supporting her family, including her four year old child. However, in August 2020, even with documentation of the register and the UNHCR identification, she was detained right at her residence by the police. She was sent to a refugee camp in Chaguaramas where she was tested for COVID-19 along with other fellow refugees. Several of them, who didn't suffer any symptoms, were still diagnosed with positive results for these tests. All of these events and actions are clear evidence of xenophobia against the Venezuelans, the police and those at the refugee camps did these kinds of actions out of hatred and dislike towards the community because of their mass arrival to Trinidad; these people only have to go through one crisis to another.

"Recently there was a young girl trafficked and the family contacted me because they (abductors) were asking for ransom. The family was afraid to report it to the police because they may kill them. They threatened them. all of that is going on right now." (Yesenia Gonzales, *The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*) These words come from Yesenia Gonzales, a social activist for Venezuelans, who spoke recently in September 2024 about fears from Venezuelans towards the Xenophobia of the authorities, the police who are supposed to follow the law. *"Some police officers are involved in human trafficking, as you know."*, (*The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*) Gonzales said. The xenophobic violence in Trinidad has passed a boundary where inhumane crimes like trafficking minors are dangerous to report to the police as a Venezuelan who is trying to save his own family.

The rising homicide rate in Trinidad and Tobago has often been blamed by the recent Venezuelan arrival to the islands. Nevertheless, there are a variety of factors that show this xenophobic view is not exactly correct. *"Rivalries, particularly between the Sixx and Rasta City gangs, and easy access to weapons have fueled bloodshed in the twin-island Caribbean nation, as they vie for the spoils from illegal gambling, human smuggling, and robberies, among other criminal activities."* (*InSight Crime*) Some of the spoils desired by these two notorious gangs that led to the rapidly increasing homicide rate include human smuggling, or trafficking. If Venezuelans are massively trafficked out of their own will, and murder is happening because of the inhumane crimes committed against them, then, it is an offense to put blame and insult a humble community that is exploited against the increasing murders, and in some cases it is hypocrisy.

The xenophobia against the Venezuelans has escalated to a point where the mass homicide rates happening at the moment has all been blamed on their arrival. They are fleeing from a humanitarian crisis in their country for the sake of their survival only to be arrested, deported, trafficked, and insulted in their new home. *"The more you create xenophobia is the worse Trinidad and Tobago will get."* (Yesenia Gonzales, *The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*) said the activist Yesenia Gonzales. While it cannot be mistaken that some Venezuelans can be blamed for their crimes, most are only in the country with the purpose of sustaining a life where they can financially provide for their families. The continuation of this xenophobia will only shape Trinidad and Tobago as a corrupt nation that commits atrocities against their life-seeking refugees.

Mutual Economic Growth

Employment Opportunities

Lucia sold street food in Güiria to provide for herself and her family. *“We usually don’t find any options to survive. Food is scarce and very expensive. We just want to work.”* (The New Humanitarian) She struggled in making money in order to purchase basic necessities, which suffered from hyperinflation due to the humanitarian crisis in Venezuela. These are the types of critical situations that impulse individuals to search the closest location to earn a well-paying and sustaining job that they can save their families with.

While not Venezuelan, Robin has been forced to move to Trinidad from Cuba in order to receive job opportunities that his country doesn’t allow. *“If I leave Cuba for over a year, I lose my permits and my residency there; I can’t go back and haven’t gone back since.”* Robin has a wife and a daughter who he hasn’t seen since she was 1 years old. He had veterinarian experience and is now in Trinidad helping pets in homes as well as other domestic services. Despite said experience, the job opportunities in Cuba were minimal, forcing him to search places with better chances and salaries even outside of his country.

A series of graphs and measurements recorded in 2019 by the IOM informed that, in terms of jobs of Venezuelans before and after, there was a massive jump between construction jobs, with 15% of respondents working on construction in Venezuela and now 46% have decided to dedicate to that employment. Tourism and entertainment has also seen quite a difference from 3% in Venezuela to 9% in Trinidad. However, in jobs involving education, 16% in Venezuela has dropped to a miniscule 1%. *“When asked about the sector that they worked in only 16% of the interviewees had continued working in their pre-migration work sectors after their arrival in Trinidad and Tobago.”* (International Organization for Migration). In terms of job opportunities, there had been a mass majority of Venezuelans that were forced to move into a new sector of employment, giving them a lack of experience and more struggles in order to commit and perform their jobs to the fullest.

The COVID-19 Pandemic was a hard and harsh hit against the Venezuelan workers who arrived during the period of registration. According to the International Organization for Migration’s DTM of the year 2020, 68% of Venezuelans under employment had lost their jobs.

This was during a time where they applied for a year-long work permit only for a pandemic to ruin that last sign of hope for slight economic prosperity for their families. *“Without consistent earnings, migrants can barely afford necessities.” (International Organization for Migration).*

Several immigrants gained access to Trinidad and Tobago out of illegal migration, and in such a case there is Mariana, who arrived to the main island via boats and had to seek for higher salaries. *“Back in Venezuela, I worked as a supervisor for a restaurant.”* She said, *“And, I won good earnings, and once the country’s situation came, I retired because I wasn’t earning well anymore.”* She had retired in 2018, and arrived in Trinidad in 2020. She had worked in a handful of jobs in her first years, even at a restaurant, and this stopped because she didn’t have the papers to work in any place. *“Most of us here work in construction, in cleaning... A lot of women work in car-washing, gardening, in shops...”* She continued. Most Venezuelans work in simple services for locals and/or other migrants rather than jobs that could pay significantly better for the situation they lived in.

Other cases, where Venezuelans have papers and even degrees of profession, are still not given access to a more well-paying job. A doctor from Venezuela with an actual degree in medicine from a public university, Alejandra struggled to find a job because of the language barrier, although started cleaning homes in her first years in Trinidad and has to work at more low-income services like hair-dressing. *“I don’t need to know exactly English in order to work at cleaning homes.”* she implied. *“The problem when you’re a professional and you speak Spanish and not English, the professional opportunities are a little bit more complicated since you have to speak the language properly and perfectly to work at a hospital.”* Alejandra can’t work as a doctor in Trinidad. She moved to Trinidad as despite working as a doctor in Venezuela, she didn’t have the financial opportunities as a result of the economic crisis in her country. Alejandra needs to revalidate, which she estimates will take two years, and to repeat her studies to remember her skills. She noted that learning those new jobs was difficult, although remarked that one adapts quickly.

The more recent DTM published by the IOM in 2023 includes a graph with primary factors restraining the Venezuelans from working in Trinidad and Tobago. While the most of respondents, 28%, reported other reasons, the primary five reasons that all exceeded 10% included language barriers, lack of information, lack of documentation, care of children or elderly, and lack of work permit. Discrimination is also a reason, with only 5% of respondents

reporting this. The following factors prove that opportunities for employment are hardships because of the several disadvantages Venezuelans have. If these factors were considered, then the opportunities for economic growth for both thousands of lives and the country would drastically increase, thus being of mutual benefit.

The Energy Chamber of Trinidad & Tobago established a relationship in employment opportunities between undocumented and legal immigrants, mostly Venezuelans, in their data report published on December 14th, 2020. Their table, however, is more of a reflection rather than an actual report, as its table lists jobs where immigrants mostly employ in the United States of America, as they remarked: *“The Central Statistical Office of TT does not collect data on immigrants.”* (The Energy Chamber of Trinidad & Tobago). Instead, they used research from 2014 US Census Data assessed by the PEW research center, which in the end has a connection in comparison to the US.

To begin with, 63% of workers in the services of physical appearance, such as hair stylists and beauticians, had 12% undocumented and a mass 51% legal immigrants dedicating to these services for financial growth. However, in terms of agricultural growth, the 52% that are immigrants had 30% be undocumented while only about 21% being lawful. Their report also confirms the previous fact that there is a large majority of immigrants in the construction industry, 59% of workers in this industry are part of these groups. In domestic work, such as housekeeping and cleaning homes, the two groups had an almost equal share of 24% (undocumented) to 26% (lawful) as 50% of the population at the time that was dedicated to this occupation were immigrants. All of these aren't formal jobs that have connections with some types of employment that Venezuelans in Trinidad take, which is evident with some similarities such as the large numbers contributing to the construction industry.

This source, along with its diagram, concludes that Venezuelan migrants dedicate themselves to low-end, informal jobs that are not as taken by the locals themselves. Their only opportunities mostly went towards domestic and more unskilled services, which had their own signs of criticism: *“The working conditions are often hard or unpleasant and involve a certain level of insecurity and are usually dead end, offering limited opportunities for advancement.”* (The Energy Chamber of Trinidad & Tobago). They concluded that the rising domestic unemployment rate since 2009 in the islands made it harder for the equal spread of jobs across the society of Trinidad and Tobago and it is the government's responsibility to offer

sector-specific work permits to Venezuelans in order to produce more goods for exportation and internal consumption rather than continuing to import, which would increase in a scenario where a service like a bar has to import further alcoholic drinks; the Gross Domestic Product of the country would have an increase.

Nevertheless, economic growth for Venezuelans has not completely ceased and there has been a recent case reported by the Trinidad and Tobago news channel, CNC3. *“The Ministry of National Security has extended the work permit exemption to December 31, 2025, instead of December 21 this year under the Immigration (Exemption From Work Permit) (Venezuelan Nationals) (Amendment) Order.”* (CNC3) The work permit exemption, which allows Venezuelans to work under the law for a longer time, was applied to Venezuelan nationals who registered and renewed their documents, meaning that there has been a trace of effort in order to allow the migrants to earn wealth.

Under Minimum Wage

Ernesto’s story reflects the hardships Venezuelans go through with the salaries and money they earn in Trinidad. While his earnings surpassed minimum wage earnings in Trinidad at certain moments (\$17.5 TTD per hour), Ernesto’s earnings slowly got worse, to the point where he had to seek small jobs desperately to help his family in hunger. His earnings hit a point where in July 2020, he had to request his landlord to cut the electricity in his home in order to be able to pay his own rent, as he would rather endure nights of sweat rather than live outside, in great danger from the individuals with xenophobic views towards them. *(University of West Indies)* There are times when Venezuelans in Trinidad aren’t offered the same opportunities for jobs as the locals.

Multiple Venezuelans have admitted suffering injustices in terms of how they were paid on their jobs. *“If (the work) is hard and underpaid, it's for us. The Trinidadians do not accept to work for the salaries we do,”* (Jusoor Post) This is coming from a Venezuelan car-washer who’s wage averaged \$3 USD per hour. Furthermore, a construction worker also had some words about his own salaries. *“Sometimes the boss doesn't pay you the hours you worked because he knows you can't report it, they take advantage,”* (Jusoor Post) To put it simply, Venezuelans have been exploited by their bosses in their jobs in terms of how well they are paid. A primary reason for

why they left Venezuela was because of the lower wages they received in that country. What point is there to stay when wages will be the same or even worse than the place you left?

The IOM's 2019 survey found data regarding the wages of the Venezuelans within the islands. *"98.6% of respondents working in the informal sector and 76% of those working in the formal sector had not signed a contract and/or had no proof of payment for their services."* (International Organization for Migration) Not receiving any sort of evidence for their wages is suspicious in the case for the Venezuelans, and ironically enough, the same source indicated that 25% of formal workers and 30% of informal workers weren't receiving more or equal to minimum wage at the time in both hourly and monthly payments. Not to mention, but 26% of respondents, mostly in the construction sector, were either not paid in full or at all based on their employment status. There were some respondents who even reported physical and sexual assault at their low-paying jobs.

In fact, the Trinidad Express found there are more recent instances where minimum wage isn't even applied or considered with Venezuelan workers. In early 2024, there was an increase with the minimum wage to \$20.5 TTD an hour. Regardless, the Trinidad Express was able to record the cases of migrant workers in sectors of minimum wage. Some continue to earn the old minimum wage of \$17.5 an hour or less. For example, a Venezuelan employee at a food outlet located at East Trinidad, earning \$156 per 12 hours, equivalent to \$13 an hour, not to mention this person has worked there for three years. To continue, another worker at Chaguanas who earned only \$18 an hour. These underpaid workers particularly work in sectors or services such as commerce, construction, domestic work, and tourism.

"Migrants, particularly those who are unregistered run the risk of being paid below the minimum wage." (The Trinidad Express) These words come from Andreina Briceño Ventura-Brown of La Casita Hispanic Cultural Center at Arima. There is exploitation against the vulnerability of undocumented migrants when it comes to being paid for their efforts at their employment. The Trinidad and Tobago Ministry of Labour indicated in their announcement of the new minimum wage that it applied to both documented and undocumented migrants in the country, and that those who didn't comply would be held accountable. However, the employers in Trinidad and Tobago have not just paid under minimum wage, but also made illegal deductions, such as the inability for Venezuelans to claim their National Insurance contributions (CIS).

In order for their personal gain, employers use the mass demands for work deriving from the migrants in order to hire them for lower costs and greater job retention as they would envision the job as an opportunity rather than the reality; a scam illegal under the laws of the Ministry of Labour. The regulations concerning wages are harder to enforce in the informal sectors, which unfortunately over 30%, as according to the 2022 DTM of the International Organization for Migration.

Speaking of the Displacement Tracking Matrix of the IOM, the 2023 version had 23% of respondents working in informal sectors reported their payments to be under minimum wage, which had increased less than a month after the release of that DTM, implying that the difficulty to keep track of migrant workers in terms of being paid over minimum wage increased that cases of underpaid workers are prone to increase drastically. This has reached to the point where employers have failed to comply with the regulations involving the recent minimum wage.

Fortunately, there have been efforts placed by the Ministry of Labour against employers and businesses that fail to pay minimum wage to their workers. *“According to the ministry, businesses can be fined \$15,000 for non-compliance, which includes paying under the minimum wage, failure to keep records and unauthorised deductions.” (The Trinidad Express)* Despite the penalties, migrants maintained fear of retaliation against employers who they accused for violating the law of minimum wage. Ventura-Brown of La Casita helped both raise awareness regarding the wage rights for Venezuelan migrant workers as well as motivating and supporting those who fear or are treated unfairly by their employers. The Ministry of Labour has the responsibility to establish stronger enforcement mechanisms against the employers who fail to pay migrant workers past minimum wage while ensuring they do not harm or seek revenge against those who accused them of their crimes.

According to The Energy Chamber of Trinidad & Tobago, there exist impacts on wages for both Venezuelans and locals in Trinidad with their arrival. The job market is in higher demand due to a mass migration of thousands of people in a country. This means that the rising competition for jobs reduces the wages in unskilled labour. However, this is due to a domination of the supply shift by the demand, and the distribution of jobs is unbalanced. It is the job of Trinidad and Tobago to encourage labour in their more underdeveloped sectors, like agriculture and manufacturing, rather than informal services. This way, wages could increase for the Venezuelans and locals while also being highly contributing to the economy of the nation.

The arrival of Venezuelans in Trinidad and Tobago has allowed several businesses and individuals to take advantage of their desperate situation and paid them significantly less than what they deserved for risking their lives in order to seek better opportunities for themselves. Yes, there have been efforts to cease the employers who fail to follow the laws of minimum wage. Exploiting through paying under minimum wage to refugees only develops a negative image on the islands at an international level.

Access to Human Rights

Accessibility to Health

“Once, I went to the hospital with a Neuritis pain, and they attended me well.” Mariana stated. *“But I’ve had friends who’ve gone and experienced xenophobia.”* These are her words regarding healthcare in Trinidad and Tobago. According to the IOM’s Displacement Tracking Matrix report of 2023, 94% of respondents primarily opted for public hospitals, while 3% for private and the rest went for NGOs or others. In other words, there is clearly a high demand for hospitals that are more exposed to xenophobia and a lack of professional resources from the malnourished and ill migrants.

All refugees, regardless of their situation, had access to emergency and primary healthcare, as according to Amanda Solano of the UNHCR. Giving birth, maternal health for pregnant women, and vaccines. However, what they do not have access to are secondary and tertiary healthcare, which provide treatments for life-risking illnesses like High Blood Pressure, Cancer, and Diabetes.

In the DTM of 2023, reasons existed for migrants and refugees to be unable to access services for the sake of their health. Out of respondents without access to healthcare, 46% were out of discrimination, 25% from stigma and 25% from language barriers. An interviewee for this survey concluded that the mistrust and lack of information for certain services are difficulties faced by migrants when accessing healthcare. Furthermore, the needs section in this same report has data regarding the views of migrants towards the medical care in the islands. In a graph for the first priority of Venezuelans in Trinidad, 12% regarded healthcare at their utmost necessity.

For this same exact survey, the graph serving as a rating for basic needs had medical / healthcare as the second highest in terms of dissatisfaction by 20%, only behind education, which had 22%.

Some other data found within this survey included 30% of the migrants concerned over being diagnosed with mental and physical health problems. Not to mention, 21.2% of migrants reported a need to attend medical services over a mental health problem, while 45.2% reported the same for physical health problems. *“Our findings suggested that almost half of our study population reported experiencing health challenges which required medical attention.”*

(National Library of Medicine) Simply put, migrants are in desperate need of medical assistance and it is the country's liability to offer these rights to all of their citizens. The migration journey has only ruined the health of these individuals further, establishing a need for these people to access healthcare.

An interview was held with Doctor Nyla Lyons, who, according to the Trinidad & Tobago Guardian, is a public health specialist with over 15 years of experience that has collaborated with various agencies, organizations and governments across the subregion that is the Caribbean. In her interview, she points out many details regarding the health and access to medical care for the Venezuelan migrants in Trinidad and Tobago. With the arrival of Venezuelans, the demand and reliance on the public healthcare system has skyrocketed. This is evident as by the end of 2020, 71% of Venezuelan migrants found themselves accessing healthcare services through public hospitals.

Like mentioned on the Dangers of Migration, Venezuelans reach the country in serious conditions considering the voyage they embark in and the crisis they had to live through in their country. Pre-existing health conditions, as attested by the interview, involve hypertension, diabetes, and disorders of anxiety, which existed in 48% of the participants within Doctor Lyons' survey financed by a grant at the University of West Indies to the medical research foundation with 250 respondents. Not only this, but 76% found themselves testing for human immunodeficiency virus (HIV) within the span of a year. Meanwhile, 80% of respondents either tested for pregnancy or purchased condoms at a health center. This survey was done with the idea that 76% of respondents accessed care through public hospitals and health centers, while 10% relied on NGOs and the rest on private hospitals and pharmacies. Conducted between September 2020 and November 2020 with 92% of the respondents living in Trinidad between 1 to 4 years at the time, an estimation had been found where over 120,000 Venezuelans lived with

HIV back in 2019, with 79% of these respondents confirming limited access back in their homeland due to the economic crisis.

The interview with Doctor Lyons has shown the contribution demonstrated by non-Governmental organizations towards the rapidly demanding healthcare centers in Trinidad and Tobago. The UNHCR reported 157 consultations conducted in February 2021 by one of these organizations, the Family Planning Association of Trinidad and Tobago, (FPATT) that had 157 health consultations thanks to medical innovations such as telehealth and onsite consultations in more remote locations like Moruga or Tobago. *“We have an agreement with them (FPATT) since they provide healthcare services at a lower cost. It’s much lower and there are even cases where they can make exceptions.”* says Amanda Solano. UNHCR works with this organization to ensure the health care of migrants that are most vulnerable to health issues.

Other NGOs, like the Medical Research Foundation of Trinidad and Tobago (MRFTT), have contributed to the effort for the health of the Venezuelans through partnerships with other local NGOs such as the Living Water Community. Their combined efforts have provided services with migrants and refugees such as screenings for diabetes and hypertension, HIV and STI testing, and pregnancy testing. Fortunately, this NGO has collaborated with the Government of the country to investigate and figure out the method to control the HIV and NLTV-1 diseases. Thus, it has become the largest HIV treatment centre in the country, which is positive considering their relationship with the Venezuelan migrants.

The professional doctor is asked a question regarding her opinion on how the country can address the medical needs of Venezuelans while minimizing risks and burdens on the already highly demanded public health system. She suggests that the government is liable in their consideration of a policy that encourages the provision of health services for the migrants and refugees. There was also a remark about the spread of information about health services in public centers and NGOs to have migrants test for infections like HIV to reduce the risk of its dissemination. If the disease is spread, then the worsening conditions of those diagnosed with it will be forced into hospitalization. *“The cost of hospitalisation represents a larger burden on the public healthcare system in the long run.”* (Nyla Lyons, *The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian*) The reliance on the public healthcare system suggests prolonged times to wait for attendance, which negatively affects both the Venezuelans and the locals in terms of health.

An article analyzing and interpreting a survey of 250 respondents at the National Library of Medicine (NIH) was published by Nyla Lyons and Brendon Bhagwandeem in October 2023. Their results showed details about health care and its services with Venezuelan refugees and migrants. Out of 250, 221, or 88.4% of the respondents concluded that they did not have a trace of knowledge about accessing healthcare in the country upon arrival. The data from the survey also finds connections between the accessibility of healthcare services to factors such as length of stay, level of income, household dynamics, and reasons for migration.

“I’ve always taken private healthcare.” Samuel had lived in Trinidad since 2002, as a part of his family is from the islands and one of his main reasons for moving was to learn the English language to a higher proficiency. *“Have I felt threatened? No.”* He responded. *“I arrived in 2002, and it wasn’t a problem considering now there are a lot. When I arrived, they didn’t believe I was Venezuelan, but American, British. I didn’t feel as much Xenophobia since I was able to speak English.”* All the factors in the survey connected with Samuel. The survey revealed that those who had lived in Trinidad for longer than 12 months were more likely to seek public health services than those who had arrived under this time. As someone who has lived for a long time, he pours a lot of trust and confidence, reporting that the locals are welcoming and nice to him. The survey also found that 100% of the respondents who had the reason to reunite with families sought for public health care. He lives with his brother, where it is described by the data that by 69.3%, migrants living with family or friends have sought medical care. However, only 40.9% of those living alone have done so.

While he only attends private healthcare, Samuel has found himself as one of few Venezuelans who can feel connection with the people of Trinidad, although data still shows information like 54.5% of asylum seekers in risk of deportation when attending these hospitals. The building of mistrust puts the lives of the migrants on a decision that has too much risk for a reward. This fear of deportation causes a discussion where policies are suggested to be made to build more trust and to ensure the healthcare of more migrants is assured. Not to mention, on the same survey results published in the NIH, migrants that earn under \$1000 TTD were found to be further likely to seek public health care, and considering the wages given to a large amount of Venezuelans only implies the increase in demand for the public healthcare system in Trinidad and Tobago for the migrants and refugees.

Responses towards the necessity for improvement on medical care in the nation, especially for migrants, continues with the NGO La Casita Hispanic Cultural Centre. In an interview with Andreina Briceño Ventura-Brown of this organization, she reported about the long hours that were endured by the migrants in the public hospitals. Some wouldn't be attended at all out of xenophobia or the genuine pressure given by such high demand. On April 9, 2024, also World Health Day, the organization released a public statement on social media: *"These marginalised populations often endure arduous journeys, fleeing from communities affected by war, conflict, natural disasters, and economic crises, only to encounter barriers to healthcare upon arrival."* (The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday) La Casita argued over the lack of a national policy involving the health care of migrants in the country. They advocated for the right for health for these human beings who are already in bad conditions considering what they had to endure in Venezuela and the trip to Trinidad.

Healthcare in Trinidad and Tobago has been essential for Venezuelans, and it has been able to treat many who had to fight through the rough conditions of the journey and their home country. Several NGOs see the need for policies to be placed and action to be taken by the Government of Trinidad and Tobago as well as their Ministry of Health to address the situation involving the necessity for this basic human right and the highly demanded public healthcare system. Loads of cases of infections such as HIV, mental and physical health problems are all necessities for migrants which cannot be treated properly or at all. Several NGOs, such as FPATT, MRFTT, Living Water Community and La Casita have taken responsibility for several of the treatment and advocating for this basic human right when it is the government and the role of those dedicated to medical care's that needs to continue supporting and ensuring the health of their migrants and refugees is assured and balanced.

Absence of an Education

UNICEF reported that in Venezuela, before the COVID-19 school closures, 856,000 students had dropped out of their education as a result of the crisis. Education is a basic right, for all children across the world, and Trinidad and Tobago is no exception. With more than 2,000 Venezuelan children, there was a timeline of more than five years regarding the access of education for Venezuelan migrants, until recently when the Minister of Education and Minister of National Security in Trinidad and Tobago decided to act upon the issue.

Back in 2019, during the registration process of thousands of Venezuelans, it was originally unavailable for young children to receive a formal education. *"No Education"*, responded Charmaine Gandhi-Andrews, the Chief Immigration Officer at the time during live news. *"Minister was clear about that, a lot of the NGO's are actually facilitating them by creating curriculum that the Venezuelans would use."* Originally, it was the job of the non-governmental organizations to provide education for the registered children in Trinidad and Tobago.

This was the case for the NGO Is There Not a Cause (ITNAC), where they opened a school for migrant children that held 100 children between the ages of 4-18. At the time, the Minister of Education, Anthony Garcia, had made it officially clear that migrant children were not receiving placements on local education systems. These types of programs allowed children to not just earn an education, but to interact with Trinidadian children and to learn about each other. The team leader of this NGO, Avonelle Hector-Joseph, reported some plans that he could incorporate into his program, such as academic aspects and extracurricular activities. However, he also highlighted the importance of a psychologist, Greicy Gonzalez, of the Living Water Community NGO that also contributed to the effort to help migrants and refugees. *"As one can appreciate, that kind of transition...even the journey on the boat...from Venezuela to Trinidad (was) very very traumatic,"* (Avonelle Hector-Joseph, *The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian*) Education back in 2019 was highly supported by these organizations, although couldn't sustain as many children considering their lower financial status compared to the government.

Around that same time, the Huellitas de Amor shelter program and school (Footprints of Love) was founded as part of the Hermandad sin Fronteras social organization (Brotherhood without Borders) in July 2019. Led by Thairis Lopez, this organization derived sympathy from witnessing Venezuelan children sleeping out in the Queen's Park Savannah awaiting the government's allowance for registration. *"Due to the lack of opportunities for migrant children to enter the local educational system, we decided to give these children a place where they can educate themselves, learn and grow as good citizens while their parents work for their families,"* (Thairis Lopez, *The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*). This school, along with several others, collaborate between each other in order to establish and ensure both the safety and education of the migrant children who weren't given the opportunity to learn by Trinidad and Tobago's ministry of education.

“Meanwhile, for the students that aren’t studying in a formal education,” Continued Amanda Solano of the Trinidad and Tobago UNHCR, “us UNHCR and UNICEF provide support for a virtual platform called ‘Equal Place’, where some children can study. However, this platform does not credit primary school, which is one of the challenges so everybody can get into a national system of education.” The option of a virtual school has become available for the thousands of students who suffer from lacking a formal education in Trinidad and Tobago. Ever since its development in 2019, 1,400 migrant students were enrolled in Equal Place in October 2021. There was a claim by the one who is in charge of the approval, the National Security minister: *“This matter is not in front of me as Minister of National Security in any official way.”* (Fitzgerald Hinds, *The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday*). These international organizations continue advocating for the access to education for all refugees, in which Trinidad showed great objection for too long regardless of the more than two thousand children who were in need.

The Displacement Tracking Matrix of the IOM of 2023 contains a graph showing the difference between the latest level of completed education each had. A massive 57% of migrants had finished secondary school at their highest level. Meanwhile, 15% only finished primary school, and 17% their undergraduate studies. The cycle of poverty is possible to be broken if children grow with degrees in order for them to earn professional jobs, which highlights the importance of allowing Venezuelan children to continue pursuing their education in Trinidad as it can give them the opportunity to financially support their families as they can earn a job that offers a well-paying income.

On September 4th, 2023, the minister of education, Dr Nyan Gadsby-Dolly outlined the necessity for certain legal requirements to be met before the first cohort of Venezuelan children were allowed to access a formal education. *“Before Migrant Children can enter schools,”* initiated the minister, *“Immigration division and the Aegis office have to work out the issue of student permits. Until the law is adjusted, migrant children cannot enter our schools legally. The first cohort of students to be integrated and the receiving schools have already been identified. Once legal arrangements have been finalized, they will be registered.”* (Nyan Gadsby-Dolly, *TTT Live Online*). For over four years, Venezuelan children had waited for a government-supported school to finally open for their benefit. Minors who arrived back in 2019 grew four years, likely without an education and enduring forced child labour in order to support their families.

Finally, five years after the registration of thousands of Venezuelans back in 2019, it was announced by The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian, as well as several other sources, that by September 2024, Venezuelan children with parents legally registered into the country would have the opportunity to apply for an education. The announcement came from the minister of education at the opening of a steelpan facility at Russell Latapy Secondary School. *“We have identified a group of students who are ready to transition and so we are working to get them into some schools under the Catholic Education Board.”* (Nyan Gadsby-Dolly, *The Trinidad & Tobago Guardian*). As for the children with undocumented parents, Coordinator Angie Ramnarine of the La Romain migrant support group revealed that those children would be attending child-friendly spaces constructed by the United Nations International Children’s Emergency Fund (UNICEF), although still weren’t given a government-funded education.

“After amending the country’s immigration regulations in 2024, the 2,421 Venezuelan children who were registered with the Government finally became eligible for public school enrollment.” (United Nations) This was achieved with the collaboration of a handful of United Nations agencies, this includes the UNHCR, UNICEF, and IOM. On one hand, UNHCR distributed supplies to 17 students prior to the start of the school year, while on the other hand UNICEF brought grants for the Venezuelans in their ownership and access to uniforms, textbooks, and transportation. The UN also implies that their access to education will both prepare children to contribute to the labor market of the islands and contribute to the Trinidadian’s mastery of a second language.

However, at the enrollment for the First Cohort, only 60 of 148 children met the admission criteria during their enrollments. Their acceptance came out of their possessions of a birth certificate and an immunization record. While those 60 have been, as labeled by the UN, *“an important step in Trinidad and Tobago’s commitment to fully meeting its obligations under the Convention on the Rights of the Child.”*, there remained over 2,000 Venezuelans under the age of 18 who didn’t receive an education from a government-funded school. The minister of foreign affairs, on January 21st, Amery Browne had notified that parents of children who didn’t attend the registration exercise of 2019 weren’t eligible to have their child access a formal education; a student permit exemption. This wasn’t the only requirement, through: *“Browne explained the Ministry of Education’s policy requires the parents of eligible children to present their permit from the Minister of National Security, a certified translation of the child’s birth*

certificate, the child's immunisation record, proof of address and a passport-sized photo of the child.” (TT Loop News)

While the minister for foreign affairs mentioned alternatives such as non-governmental organizations and religious groups, activists like Yesenia Gonzales considered the violation of human rights committed on the children in Trinidad and Tobago. *“What is different? Children are children. The first human rights law is to protect children and allow them to get education and medical attention.” (Yesenia Gonzales, The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday)* Her words came after receiving news in August 2024 regarding the 23 of the First Cohort at the time.

The news came from the Minister of National Security, Fitzgerald Hinds, and Minister of Education, Nyan Gadsby-Dolly, and Chief Education Officer Dr Peter Smith. The first two agreed that their decision was under the law, where Gadsby-Dolly stated that the Ministry of Education could not be driven by emotion. Dr Smith had found that on behalf of the 187 applications for Venezuelan children's access to a formal education, 111 were successful after interviews, and the last 23 due to the expired documents, low literacy rates, and lack of translators for several of the children. Nevertheless, Gonzales saw this as “Discrimination” against the undocumented and unregistered immigrants, where she lamented over the inability for the mass number of children to receive that formal education. *“Claiming Guyana educates all children regardless of status, she alleged TT is now in a ‘position of international embarrassment.’” (The Trinidad and Tobago Newsday)*

The ministers of Trinidad and Tobago agree that the miniscule acceptance of Venezuelan children within their borders was because they followed the law that the overwhelming majority did not. Some migrants are in desperate need of an education because they need to help their families once they come of age. While the number of children under a formal education slowly increases, and the September 2024 registration of Venezuelan migrants to a formal education was a significant step considering the five years since the registration period of 2019, the acceptance of larger numbers would allow the construction of more minds to work professionally, supporting Trinidad and Tobago while ensuring Venezuelan families remain out of poverty and continue educating their children in order to profit from their academic experience.

Conclusion

At a younger age, I witnessed videos of the humanitarian crisis in Venezuela and the mass migration that derived from it. Living in Colombia at the time, I started to see a rise and the arrival of these communities who sought for better opportunities. When arriving in Trinidad a few years later, I saw the same communities in danger and desperation of the issues that they had to endure in the islands. I always visualized something that I didn't fully understand. I decided to work on this research project in order to investigate their main issues profoundly, to witness what was hiding from me throughout such a long period of time. Thus, I was able to understand and type not just the premise of Venezuelans arriving in Trinidad in recent memory, but the role of the individuals, locations, laws, timeline, ministries, and the government behind this whole phenomenon.

The research paper included interviews with a handful of Venezuelans who had stories to tell about their experiences, as well as many other stories deriving from the sources investigated to craft this. Their information gave me first hand evidence of what they had to go through and allowed me to make connections and analyze whole situations that were occurring with their integration in this country. However, in this paper, only four individuals of different professions were interviewed. For a broad paper like this one, more voices could've been useful to provide more personal information from the migrants themselves.

While most of the paper includes the negatives of the Venezuelan migrants and refugees throughout their incorporation into Trinidad and Tobago, there is no mistake that ministries, governments, and locals have contributed to the arrival of these individuals. It is no simple task to maintain control when thousands of people both legally and illegally are arriving to a pair of small islands within one year. Their integration was inevitable to have several issues, which is also the case for multiple countries that receive them like Colombia. Despite this, it is unacceptable to treat individuals who fled from deadly situations like that.

This research paper has allowed me to understand how Venezuelans are treated, exploited, trafficked, insulted, and integrated into Trinidad & Tobago. It has changed the way I've visualized them over six years and has allowed me to give them respect for what they've had to fight and go through both in Venezuela and here. I want readers of this research paper to feel the same way based on all of these issues combined that have to be addressed by the

government of the country until Venezuela is in a better position. According to the IOM's Displacement Tracking Matrix, 71% of the survey respondents had no idea when they would leave Trinidad and Tobago. There is no assurance of when Venezuela will finally be fixed from its crisis. After Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro's third term and US President Donald Trump's position in office, the sanctions imposed on this country will grow worse for the citizens of the decaying country, or it will mark the end for the rule of the PSUV political party since Hugo Chávez's position.

At this time, it is a priority for Venezuelans to continue living in Trinidad and Tobago in order to be safe from the social, economic and political crisis happening in their homeland. Tensions are only growing there and thus Trinidad becomes prone to receive more migrants in need of basic rights, work permits, and proper treatments by the locals, authorities, and government. Hence, this research paper serves as a way to allow these individuals to broadly understand the situation and ensure superior quality of life for their migrants and refugees, promising that those human opportunities will be offered to them.

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